



# SICILIANS

THE ISLAND OF SICILY lies just by the southern tip of Italy. It is the largest island in the Mediterranean and the one with the richest historical and artistic heritage. Its location has been responsible for a culture that contains

LIFE NEAR EUROPE'S BIGGEST VOLCANO

## Fruits of the land and the sea

Sicily's mild climate is perfect for farming.

In fact, centuries ago, the island was one of the main suppliers of food to the entire Roman Empire. Fishing is important too, and enormous tuna, which can be 10 ft (3 m) in length and weigh up to 1,400 lbs (650 kg), are still caught in the traditional way.

### TUNA FISHING

Mass catches called *Mattanzas* occur every year when the tuna return to the Mediterranean to mate. These are necessary because at around 45 days, the fishing season is a relatively short one. A series of nets are used, and the catch starts with a prayer led by the head fisherman, or *rais*.



### SALT FROM THE SEA

Salt marshes lie between Trapani and Marsala on the west coast of the island. Salt extraction for human use here dates back to Roman times. In the 19th century salt was obtained from the water with the help of windmills.



### CITRUS ORCHARDS

Oranges and lemons were first planted in Italy during the Arab conquest of neighboring Spain. Today, orchards of citrus trees are a common sight and Sicily is famous for its oranges, particularly the ruby-red blood orange with its sour taste.

